

The Unanswered Call

The first time Lin Yi died, no one noticed, not even himself.

The sentence he had been revising for hours on his laptop—his Borges translation—sat highlighted on the screen: “With relief, with humiliation, with terror, he understood that he too was a mere appearance, dreamed by another.” The cursor blinked at the end of the line.

Rain hammered the window. Water streamed down the glass, smearing the street into green and amber streaks—the pharmacy cross, the row of streetlamps, all of it running together. He had meant to answer the message from his aunt before bed. He had meant to call tomorrow. There was always a tomorrow for small duties, until suddenly there wasn’t.

A metallic taste in his mouth, his tongue went numb with cold. Something slipped from his hand—a pen cap, perhaps—struck the wooden desk with a clean ting, and rolled into the dark. The sound was clear, lonely and eerily familiar in the empty room.

Air stopped halfway in his chest. His jaw locked. The muscles in his forearms clenched around nothing. Pain struck in bright, exact points—behind his eyes, under his ribs, along his fingertips—then spread, tight as wire. He tried to reach for the desk, for the phone, for anything solid enough to argue with, but his hand closed on air.

His vision narrowed. The edges of the room dimmed first, then the desk, then the white page on the screen. The highlighted line broke into pale blocks. Letters lost their edges. Black crept in from the corners until only the center remained—a small, shaking rectangle of light—and then that, too, went out.

When he opened his eyes, his cheek was pressed against black shale. The stone was slick and pitted, cold with mist. Rain fell in fine, ash-colored threads, so light they seemed to

hang for an instant before needling the rock — then fed thin runnels that slid toward a river the color of old lead.

The violent pain in his chest was gone, leaving only a dull pressure under his breastbone. Pushing up against the wet rock, he felt his palm scrape raw—then, just as he rose, the ground lurched. His hand shook; his balance scattered. His stomach heaved, slow and heavy, trying to lift out of him. Cold sweat broke along his spine. A hard swallow forced the sour fluid back down, but the nausea won—he bent and spat onto the rock.

He stayed on his knees until the rolling eased. Then he wiped his mouth with the back of his wrist and looked up.

The sky layered itself overhead: pale ash close enough to touch, then a thicker grey farther out, and beyond that a bruise-dark band where the fog ate distance. The river mirrored it — near the bank, a light dirty pewter; midstream, slate; farther on, a strip of black that gave back no reflection. Not dusk. Not dawn.

The river moved, yet held no life—a flat band of water sliding past without ripples. No reeds. No insects. Deep in the mist came a steady, measured sound: *plash... plash...* A pole dipped, lifted, dipped again—each stroke the same distance, the same pause, precise as an ancient metronome.

His right hand was clenched so tightly his knuckles hurt from lack of blood. He forced his fingers apart. In the sweat-damp hollow of his palm lay a small, icy disc. A coin. Silver-grey, almost rubbed smooth, one side still holding the blurred shadow of a profile.

Obol. The word arrived at once. Of course it did.

A boatman in an old story asked for one.

The familiar vibration against his thigh shattered the stillness. He fumbled the phone out. Its screen lit up, washing his damp fingers in a cold blue-green glow.

Caller ID: Mom.

Signal: No Service.

The vibration stopped. The river kept sliding past. Rain kept ticking on stone. He stared at the two lines on the screen until his eyes began to sting.

Then the phone shuddered again—same pulse, same duration. The screen refreshed. Still Mom. Still No Service.

It stopped.

He counted without meaning to. One breath. Two. Three.

It started again.

He pressed the call button anyway. The glass was slick with rainwater and sweat. He lifted the phone to his ear and listened hard. No ring. Only the dull, empty hiss of the speaker and his own breath.

He lowered the phone, jaw tight, and shoved it back into his pocket. The coin followed, thudding once against his thigh through the wet fabric. Out on the river, the measured sound had come closer.

Plash—

Plash.

The movement was slow, economical. Then it stopped, followed by a long scrape—wood against stone, or a pole dragged along a hull. A low, rust-streaked skiff slid into view, its rotting paint peeling like dead scales.

A man stood at the stern with a pole. Too tall for the craft, he had to hold himself in a slight forward bend. Wet dark cloth clung to his torso. A coarse cloak was knotted shut at one shoulder. Grey-white beard hid most of his mouth and chin. His eyes reached Lin first—steady, pale, unblinking.

The bow touched the shale with a dull click. Along the bank, half-lost in fog, other figures stood apart from one another, all facing the boat.

The boatman did not step ashore. He planted the pole, leaned forward, and held out his right hand—broad, rough, split at the creases. Water pooled in the cracks. It stayed there, palm up, waiting.

Lin looked at it. His fingers tightened around the coin. He did not take it out.

“I’m not getting on that.” The words came rough and smaller than he intended. He cleared his throat and tried again. “I need to—go back. I need to—”

Then, in a voice low and worn from disuse, he said, “Back where?”

He lifted one hand to point, then stopped. Point where. The bank behind him had already folded into fog. The shale to either side ran only a few yards before dissolving into the same blind grey. He turned once, too quickly, searching for a road, a light, a wall, anything that would admit a direction. There was nothing to name.

He dropped into a crouch and pressed both hands hard over his head, fingers digging into wet hair. Eyes shut. Think. Desk. Screen. Rain on glass. The phone in his hand. He pulled the fragments toward him and felt them slide loose again.

“I just passed out,” he said, not looking up now, speaking into his own sleeve. “There has to be a way back—”

Then he opened his eyes and pointed uselessly over his shoulder into the fog, toward a world that had already withdrawn from view. “I need a signal,” he said. “I need to make a call.”

The boatman’s gaze dropped, not to Lin’s face but to the pocket where the phone and coin weighed the cloth down. “No one hears clearly from the bank where they fall.”

Lin swallowed. “What does that mean?”

“It means,” the boatman said, still holding out his hand, “if there is any road forward, it is across the water.”

Lin said nothing.

Somewhere inside the pocket, the phone gave one small, trapped vibration. Lin flinched and reached for it at once.

“If I get in,” Lin said, forcing the words into something steadier than panic, “I keep this?” His fist tightened around the coin. “I keep my phone. My memories.”

The boatman gave the slightest shift of the shoulder. “Bring what you can carry.”

“And the call?”

The boatman looked past him into the fog. “Board the boat,” he said. “Keep what is yours. Perhaps what seeks you will answer there.”

Lin stood very still. Then he looked at the screen again.

Caller ID: Mom.

Signal: No Service.

His thumb moved once over the cracked glass. He could stay on the bank and keep failing in exactly the same way. Or he could risk being fooled. At least that was movement.

Slowly, without trusting the choice, he stepped toward the boat.

Lin drew the coin from his pocket. The metal left his skin and, with it, a small, irrational sense of safety.

The boatman rolled the coin once between thumb and forefinger and set it down on the gunwale beside him. “Get in.”

Lin climbed aboard.

The skiff dipped under him. Wet wood shifted beneath his shoe; his foot slid half an inch before he caught the side hard. He pulled himself in with an awkward surge and dropped onto the nearest plank, then straightened his back at once, arranging his posture into something that might pass for calm.

Cold moved through him in one steady wave and stayed. It found his cuffs, his collar, the thin places in his clothing, then settled against his skin.

The pole drove into the water. The boat slid away from shale.

Lin turned to keep the bank in sight. The black rock held for a few breaths, then blurred into fog.

He took out his phone.

He lifted it, lowered it, angled it toward the sky, toward the water, toward the boatman’s back. One bar would have been enough. There was nothing.

Lin put the phone away, then pulled it out again immediately, checked the screen again, and forced himself to put it away. The repetition made his hands look foolish.

“Excuse me,” Lin said. The words came out careful, controlled. He tried again, softer. “Could you stop for a moment?”

The boatman did not turn.

He kept his hands on his knees after that, fingers laced tight, and stared into the fog ahead.

A new weight gathered in his shoulders. Not fatigue—something denser. His neck stiffened. When he lifted his head, the motion resisted, slow and stubborn, like joints packed with wet sand. His breath shortened. Pressure tightened behind his eyes. He shut them once—hard—and in the sudden darkness, a voice surfaced.

“When are you coming back?”

The answer rose on his tongue before he could catch it—a sentence polished by years of storage.

“Soon. Just let me finish this.”

He opened his eyes and swallowed. The boat continued its steady glide through grey.

His gaze fell. The coin stayed where it was placed. He palmed the coin and drew back at once, closing his fist around it. Cold bit into his skin. He kept the fist low, pressed against his thigh, and let his other arm fold across his middle, holding himself together. The phone failed him. The shore was gone. That’s the only thing he could hold.

When the hull settled, he turned his head toward the water. Alongside the hull, the river held a thin strip of sheen—one narrow place where it caught the light. In that strip a face appeared.

Not anyone he recognised. A man with a higher forehead and a thinning hairline, cheeks drawn in too far, skin slack at the throat; his mouth hung slightly open, breath caught mid-syllable. The eyes were the worst part—not because they were strange, but because they

were terrified in a way Lin understood at once, wide and raw, staring up from the moving black.

He jerked back, the boat tilted, his shoulder struck the gunwale, and his hand flew open.

The coin slipped free, struck the floorboards, and rang out—

Ting.

The boatman's pole stopped for a beat. Lin's hand shot down and closed over the coin before the sound finished dying. He kept it in his fist, low by his knee.

Suddenly, a red seam seeped up where wood met water. It ran along the grain in hair-thin lines, then thickened, branching into the planks with quiet insistence. The first curled tips pushed through the damp boards and opened, petals hooked back on themselves, wet and glossy in the grey.

The skiff shuddered.

Something punched through from below. The plank gave with a sharp split, and river water surged in, cold enough to burn through cloth. The boat listed and water slid across the floorboards in a sudden sheet.

The boatman swore under his breath and drove the pole down hard. He swung the pole with both hands. Wood struck vine. Red sap burst and smeared the boards. He struck again, then again, each blow placed to clear the gunwale and free his own feet.

The vines kept coming. They climbed the stern, looped the pole, and tightened around his lower leg. Another length slid up his wrist, drawing the sleeve taut.

Lin's shoe floated for a moment, bumped the bench, and turned heel-up in the rising water. He looked from the widening seam in the hull to the fog ahead, then back to the

boatman's bound arm.

He dropped to his knees and crawled to the side, keeping his weight low. The boards were slick under his palms. He hooked his fingers under the gunwale and pulled himself up enough to see the waterline.

A mat of red had spread across the surface, stems braided tight, petals pressed against petals. Vines ran off into the fog, disappearing the moment his eyes tried to follow them.

He reached for the nearest vine and hesitated only long enough to feel the cold in his chest tighten. Then he grabbed it.

Lin swung a leg over the gunwale and slid down, forearms burning as wet cloth scraped wet wood. The skiff tipped again behind him. Water climbed his shin. He kicked hard, searching for purchase and finding none, then found the red stems under him. They gave a little and steadied.

He kept both hands on the vine and pulled himself forward, dragging his body across the floating red. The river kept trying to turn his legs; he kicked, lost ground, kicked again, and moved on by inches. The vine ran on into fog and never seemed to end. After a while his forearms began to burn, then to numb, and his grip became a blunt, mechanical thing. He stopped counting strokes. He counted only breath.

Behind him, the pole struck wood with a dull, brutal rhythm. The boatman shouted once. Lin did not turn.

When the vine finally brought him close enough, his toes brushed stone beneath the surface. He found purchase, stumbled, and hauled himself the last stretch through water that fought to pull him back. He caught the edge of the shale with one hand, then the other, and

dragged himself up onto the bank.

He lay there long enough to cough up the river from his throat, spit once onto the rock, and pull air into his lungs without choking. Then he pushed himself onto his knees, shaking, and reached for his pocket.

The screen lit. Wet glass. Cold light. Not dead, then. He wiped the screen on his sleeve and checked again. Nothing changed.

Behind him, the skiff groaned as it took more water. Something in the hull split again, the sound ripping cleanly through the fog.

Lin tried to run. His shoes dragged, sodden and heavy. He bent, yanked one off, then the other, and left them where they fell. Socks followed. Bare feet met cold stone; the bite was clean and immediate.

He looked up.

Through the fog, deeper inland, an orange point held steady in the fog—not bright enough to be day, too contained to be flame. Lin headed for it at a run, driven less by hope than by the sound behind him: wood protesting, water striking, a violence that kept shifting its distance. Every few steps he glanced back.

Under his feet the spider lilies spread along shale and shallow water alike, at first in scattered threads, loose strands of blood-red silk drawn across stone, then thicker and thicker as he went, stems crossing, fine roots catching and holding, the whole growth tightening by degrees into a mesh that held to the surface without drifting. Through its seams showed the tea-coloured water below, lit by some hidden warmth, while pale steam lifted from the surface and slid past his ankles through the mist. It was nothing like the hard, leaden chill of

the farther river. Here the water held a gentler stain, like old tea steeped too long; its warmth was not trustworthy, but it was real.

After several steps, his body had changed.

The weight in his shoulders had shifted and his joints felt less locked. When he stepped carefully, the flowers received his weight and held it. When panic threw his balance forward, the red gave way beneath him, dragging at his calves with a patient resistance that nudged him back toward steadiness. The sensation was strange enough to border on tenderness. It dipped, then steadied, refusing to let him sink.

Ahead, a darker shape moved through the white.

Lin slowed.

The shape ahead took another step and gathered into a man in an oversized coat, the hem dark with damp. He stooped slightly as he walked. One leg dragged a fraction behind the other, not theatrically, not with the clean claim of fresh pain, but with the small, settled stiffness of a body that had been lived in for too long.

The man did not look back. He walked where the lilies ran thickest, placing each step with the confidence of someone who had no need to test what would bear him.

Lin gained on him by instinct and by caution. The fog delivered the smell before it delivered the man clearly: disinfectant, soap, the stale-sweet edge of old hospital corridors. Lin's stomach turned at once. The fingers wrapped around his phone went so numb he nearly dropped it.

Under the man's arm was a notebook, swollen and warped.

The corners had softened, worked thin by long handling and wet. The man shifted it

higher. The damp boards gave a faint creak. A strip of lettering showed on the spine.

Lin stopped so abruptly the flowers dipped under his heel.

His surname was there, blurred, half-drowned in moisture, yet instantly recognisable in shape.

What rose in his mind was not this object itself, but another: a cheap grey notebook, the sort sold in stationers near train stations and university gates, paper that furred at the edges, corners quickly blunted by use. He had once carried such a thing everywhere, in coat pockets, satchels, beside the bed, to kitchen tables, onto trams, until one day he had left it behind in a place of metal chairs, repeated announcements, plastic curtains breathing bad air. He remembered telling himself it did not matter. He remembered how long that decision had taken.

“Wait,” he said. The word came out too thin for the force that had produced it.

The man took one more step before stopping.

He did not turn fully, only angled his head enough to give Lin half a profile: cheek hollowed close to bone, jaw held tight, skin drawn thin across the face. His eyes moved over Lin quickly, bare feet reddened by cold, soaked sleeves, the hand locked around the phone. The look was not curious. It was appraising, tired, mildly irritated, and unnervingly economical.

“Careful,” the man said.

Lin stared at him. “That’s my—”

The man’s gaze had already dropped to the flowers beneath Lin’s feet. He tipped his chin toward a thicker run of red.

“Step there,” he said. “Not the gap.”

Lin looked down. The red beneath him had thinned. Between the stems, tea-coloured water breathed softly through. His ankle shifted. He moved where the man had indicated. At once the flowers tightened and steadied him.

The man turned forward again and resumed walking.

Lin followed, half a step behind now, watching the dragging leg, the warped notebook tucked under the man’s arm.

After several breaths he said, “You know where you’re going.”

“Well enough.”

“What is this place?”

The man gave a tired breath through his nose. “A bad place to stop talking and a worse place to stop walking. Keep up.”

Lin frowned, but followed.

After a few more steps he said, “That notebook.”

No answer.

“I said, that notebook.”

“I heard you.”

“Then answer me.”

The man shifted it higher under his arm without looking at him. “What about it.”

“It’s mine.”

That made the man stop.

He turned just enough for Lin to see the tired dislike in his face—not dislike of Lin

exactly, but of the whole exchange.

Lin stepped closer. “Where did you get it?”

“Off the path.”

“Where?”

“Behind us.”

“That is not an answer.”

The man’s mouth moved slightly, not quite a smile. “No. It’s the one you’re getting.”

Lin felt heat rise under his skin. “Have you read it?”

A pause.

Then: “Enough.”

“You had no right.”

At that, the man looked at him properly for the first time.

“No,” he said. “Neither did you.”

Lin frowned. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

But the man had already turned away and gone on, limping slightly now over a thicker run of flowers. Lin followed, angrier for having to follow.

Lin shoved the phone into his pocket, then dragged it out again almost at once and glanced at the dark screen.

“Must you.”

Lin looked up. “What?”

The man made a small impatient motion with two fingers. “That. In, out, look at nothing, put it away. Then again.”

“You’ve been watching me?”

“You make it difficult not to. You nearly put your foot through the path.” They walked several steps in silence.

Then Lin said, “It’s ringing.”

The man answered too quickly. “Yes.”

Lin turned. “You heard it?”

The man’s face changed for a second—something crossed it and was gone.

“Hard not to,” he said.

Lin watched him. “Who are you?”

The man ignored that.

Instead he said, “Watch the left side. It sinks.”

Lin said nothing.

The fog pressed in again, close enough now that the man’s shoulders kept losing their edges with each step. The back of his neck showed briefly above the collar: fine skin, sallow and overduplicate, with the look of something thinned by fluorescent light.

He stepped where he was told and felt the flowers thicken underfoot, stems tightening into a firmer lattice. Beyond the edge of the path the tea-coloured water moved slowly beneath the steam, taking the pale light and breaking it into dim gold and rose. Somewhere far ahead the orange point brightened, dimmed, brightened again, no nearer than before.

The man rubbed his thumb once over the base of his ring finger.

The gesture was so small and familiar Lin might have missed it in any ordinary light. Here it flashed with extreme clarity. A pale groove marked the finger where a ring had lived

for years and departed reluctantly. The thumb moved over it once, twice, then stalled. His fingers closed.

The man muttered something under his breath.

Lin only caught one word.

“Ginger.”

From somewhere ahead, through the steam, came the faint smell: ginger crushed under the flat of a knife, scallion dropped into oil just as it took heat, soy darkening at the edge of sweetness, wool dried beside a radiator. It struck him with the clean disorientation of memory—not a scene, only the exact air of some evening long ago in his mother’s kitchen at home.

He looked up sharply.

The man said, “Nothing.”

They went on.

Lin’s eyes dropped again to the notebook.

“Give it back.”

The man kept walking.

“I mean it.”

“So do I. Mind your footing.”

Lin reached for it then, not thinking.

The man caught his wrist at once—harder than he needed to. For a second they both froze.

Lin yanked his hand back. “Then don’t carry my things in front of me.”

For the first time, the man’s temper showed cleanly.

“Your things,” he said. “Your notebook. Your phone. Your tomorrow. You say ‘mine’ as if saying it early enough keeps anything from slipping.”

Lin went still.

The man seemed to hear himself only after the words had left him. He looked away at once.

When he spoke again, his voice was flatter. More tired than angry.

“Here. Take it, then.”

He thrust the notebook at Lin with a rough, impatient motion.

Lin caught it against his chest by reflex.

The cover was damp and faintly warm from the man’s body.

The man had already turned away.

“And keep hold of it this time.”

Lin stared at his back.

The man did not slow. “It means I’m tired of carrying things that aren’t mine.”

His hand closed around the notebook. The cover, once grey, had darkened toward the colour of soaked ash. One corner had peeled away. And closer now he could smell it clearly —cupboard wood, old dust, and beneath that the faint residue of ordinary life: kitchen oil caught on paper, cold air from a cracked window, a sleeve brushed once against a bottle of soy sauce and never properly washed. It smelled used and handled. It was less an emblem than something actually lived with.

He wanted to open it at once. But he did not.

After several steps, the man said, without looking back, “You wrote in those often.”

Lin frowned. "Sometimes."

"What for."

"To remember things."

The man gave a short nod. "Did it help."

Lin almost laughed. "What kind of question is that?"

"A plain one."

Lin looked ahead into the fog. "I wrote down whatever mattered."

The man made a sound that might have been agreement, might have been contempt.

"That's what everyone says."

Lin's jaw set. "You talk like you know me."

The answer came after a beat.

"No. I talk like an old man with a bad knee and no patience left. Keep up."

That shut Lin up for several steps.

The fog thinned around them. The white ahead tore open in narrow places, lifted in strips, and let distance through. Pale violet showed first, then a thin gold, then rose moving through the steam and catching on it. The colour spread little by little, touching the mist, the water, the path beneath their feet. Farther on, the world came out a piece at a time.

The old man walked faster.

Not much at first. Just enough for the dragging leg to show itself more clearly now that he was no longer hiding it inside a measured pace. The bad foot skimmed, caught, went on.

Lin followed.

Ting.

Porcelain again. The sound of a spoon kissing the rim of the bowl.

The man let out one breath through his nose, harsh and unsteady.

“There,” he said.

This time the word came rougher, lower, pulled out of him.

The old man quickened. It did not happen all at once. His head lifted first. Then the dragging leg struck harder, caught, recovered, and drove on. His hand closed hard at his side. The notebook under Lin’s arm knocked once against his ribs when he moved to keep up.

The fog opened and the eaves emerged first.

Their dark edges cut cleanly across the lifting white. Under them hung the orange light that had drawn him this far: a six-sided palace lantern, its silk panels gone honey-dark with heat and years. Pine boughs ran in faded green along the wooden frame. On each face, a crane stood with one foot lifted, neck bent toward water that no longer showed. The brushwork had thinned in places. Gold still held in the lines around the wings.

Lantern light slid down in layers, first catching his fingertips, then his wrist, then the damp cuff of his sleeve.

Below it stood a pavilion no larger than a roadside shelter, but built with the care of something that expected to be found. The roof rose at the corners. Steam moved under it in slow sheets. A few long pine branches leaned over the back ridge and held still in the heat. Beneath the open rail, a pool spread under the platform, its surface dark and warm, dotted with pale sleeping lilies that lay flat on the water and took the lantern-light at their rims.

The porcelain note came again.

Ting.

Not from the water. From the pavilion.

A clay stove glowed low at the center. Steam rose from a broad white pot. Beside it stood a long wooden table with bowls laid out in two even rows. White porcelain. Thin-lipped. Empty. The air held the smell that had been threading through the fog all this while: ginger, scallion, soy, and old wood damp at the seams.

Someone stood at the stove.

Lin saw the hand first.

It held the ladle close to the bowl of the handle, thumb set firm along the wood, wrist loose and exact. The ladle dipped, lifted, turned. A bowl waited under it. The soup slid in one clear line and stopped without spilling. The wrist turned back. The bowl was set down. The hand moved for the next one.

The woman wore a pale apron over dark clothes. Her hair was twisted up and pinned at the back, though several strands had come loose and clung to her cheek in the steam. When she reached for the next bowl, the sleeve slipped half an inch. The heel of her hand showed. Fine cracks crossed the skin. A pale yellow stain lingered at the edge of one fingernail.

He knew that hand.

Not from one memory, but from a thousand that had never lined themselves up until now: the hand pressing the lid down on a boiling pot, the hand feeling the heat of oil without touching it, the hand pushing a bowl toward him across a table without asking whether he was hungry, because she already knew.

“Mom,” he said. His voice cracked on it.

The hand did not stop. The ladle dipped again. Steam rose and broke around her wrist.

Lin took two steps forward before he felt himself move. The notebook slipped under his arm. He caught it, shoved it hard against the nearest post, and freed his hand. His phone was already in the other. He looked down at it once in blind habit, thumb jerking across the dark screen, then lifted his head again.

The woman reached for another bowl.

She turned only enough to set it straight beneath the ladle. And then he saw her face.

Too young. The line of the nose. The soft fold beside the mouth. The mark above the brow. The eyes lowered toward the bowls, not toward him. Her face belonged to a far-off time—to walking home through wheat fields after school, the sun low and golden, the path stretching long before her, the air smelling of dry grass and dust, the far-off promise of supper, and the world still wide and unbroken. Heat hit the back of his throat so fast. His eyes flooded at once but he did not wipe them.

He moved again.

Questions rushed him so violently that none could take shape. Are you here—did you wait—did you call again—the words jammed in his chest, one overtaking the next, none making it past his throat. Did you know. Did you forgive me. Can I still answer. He heard them all, and heard nothing. Then, through the crush, one syllable forced itself out.

“Ma.” This time the word died in his throat before it finished.

No answer. She lifted the ladle. Blew once across the surface of the bowl. Set it down.

The old man made a sound behind him.

Lin turned.

The bitterness and restraint on his face had gone. The man was not looking at the

woman. His gaze had locked onto the bowl she had just filled—the dark liquid, the steam still rising. Mouth slack. Breath short and ragged. One hand had lifted from his side, fingers half-curved toward the bowl, trembling there.

He lurched past Lin.

The bad leg nearly failed under him, but he threw his weight through it and caught the table edge with both hands hard enough to rattle the bowls. Porcelain knocked against wood.

“Please,” he said.

The word tore out of him.

He fixed his eyes on the nearest full bowl. “Let me have it.”

Lin moved at once and caught his sleeve. “Wait—”

The old man struck his hand off without even looking at him. “No.” He leaned farther over the table, fingers opening toward the bowl.

The woman lifted her eyes. Until then she had not once looked directly at either of them.

The old man’s hand shook over the bowl. “Please,” he said again, lower now, the word dragging. “No more.”

Lin stared from him to her and back. “Who are you talking to?” He heard the anger in his own voice and did not care. “What is this place? Why do you—”

No one moved. But the bowls on the table gave a small, bright rattle. Steam at the edge of the pavilion broke apart. A gust of cold rushed in under the roof, carrying river-water, torn roots, wet wood, iron.

Lin turned.

At first he saw only a dark shape shouldering through the white beyond the landing. The

smell reached Lin before the man did: river-water gone sour in the planks, wet rope, iron, crushed roots. Then the shape struck the posts with a heavy jolt and came clear: the skiff, half-flooded, one side stove in, red vines still hanging from the ribs and trailing black water across the boards.

Now he saw the ferryman clearly—the soaked beard, the torn sleeve clinging to his forearm, the cold brought in under the roof with him—and for one beat he could not make sense of anything except that he had come all this way after them.

The ferryman forced the ruined skiff against the landing and came off it with one hand still on the gunwale. Then his hand went to the side of the skiff.

A length of wet rope came away with it, thick and dark with river-water, one loop already formed where it had been hitched against the hull. He did not stop to set it. His hand closed, turned, and the slack ran through his palm. The loop opened.

Lin saw that movement and knew only one thing: it was coming toward him.

The phone slipped in his hand. He snatched it back, stumbled half a step, and struck the backs of his legs against the table. One arm came up without purpose. His body had already tried to get smaller.

The boatman cast.

The rope hissed through the damp air and passed so close to Lin's face that he felt droplets strike his cheek. For one blinding instant he thought he had not moved fast enough.

Then the pull came from behind him.

Lin jerked around.

The loop had closed high across the old man's shoulder and neck, trapping one arm

against his body. The force of it dragged him sideways into the table. Bowls leapt and rang. One tipped, spun once, and shattered on the floorboards. Soup ran hot over Lin's shoe.

The old man made a raw, broken sound and clawed at the rope.

He had not cast for Lin. Had not even looked at him. The rope had gone past him as though he were nothing in the way.

The old man's bad leg slid out under him in the spilled soup. His hip struck the table edge. The rope bit deeper when he tried to twist free.

Lin moved then, fast and badly, with no plan beyond keeping the man out of his hands. He caught him under the arm, grabbed for the back of his coat, and hauled him back before his grip could tighten.

"Let him go!"

His own voice shocked him. It came out hoarse and much louder than he meant.

The ferryman did not answer. He had already braced his feet on the wet boards and was drawing the rope back in, hand over hand, without haste, without any wasted motion.

The old man choked and dug both hands under the rope, trying to force space between it and his skin.

"Stop!" Lin shouted. "He can't breathe—"

Lin looked up and saw that the ferryman's eyes were fixed entirely on the man in his grip. He had come for one thing, and he had it.

Then the woman moved.

Lin caught it at the edge of his sight: the bowl lifted in one hand, the ladle in the other. She did not hurry. Her wrist turned, and the soup went over the rope in a full, shining sweep.

The soup struck the wet hemp and spread along it in a bright sheet. Steam burst upward. The rope smoked, slackened, and slid for one instant in the ferryman's grip.

Lin seized that instant. He dragged the old man sideways with both hands. The loop caught once at the collar, scraped across his shoulder, and came free.

The woman set down the empty bowl.

"He crossed," she said.

His weight sagged heavily into Lin and then folded forward again, both hands catching the table as a fit of coughing ran through him from chest to spine. Lin kept hold of him without meaning to. The shoulder beneath his palm was soaked where the rope had dragged across it.

In the struggle, the notebook slipped from where Lin had shoved it against the post. It struck the stone steps below the pavilion and fell open in the steam.

Steam and standing water claimed it at once. Several loose pages, cards, recipes, medical records scattered across the wet stone, instantly soaked through. Black characters, blue annotations, red circles blurred, bled, spread into one another.

Lin snatched up the notebook, shook off the water, the mud, the grit. The pages inside were dense and crowded: dates pressed into corners, medication doses crossed out and rewritten, translations broken mid-sentence, grocery totals, weekly to-do lists, reminders left for a self that kept forgetting to take its pills. One page layered over another, stacked and overlapped.

The notebook had fallen open to the last page with writing.

"April 15 — damn rain, left knee hurts more. Not going out for groceries today.

Changed the ringtone back again.

Twenty-four years now. I've reached the age you were.

And yet it feels like yesterday you called."

His fingers touched the damp, warm paper. The sentences echoed through his mind, over and over. Twenty-four years. A number both familiar and strange. The handwriting was his—but the strokes trembled, uncertain. He did not remember writing any of this.

Only then did Lin understand that the woman by the stove was not his mother. The jade pin, the long fingers, the stillness of her face—none of them belonged to the woman he had lost. He had mistaken the smell, the warmth, the waiting bowl for her.

Fear and strangeness rose in his chest, but he had no time for them. This shifting, unknowable place had already made a mockery of every scrap of reason he had left.

The ferryman drew the rope back to him, the wet line dark around his forearm, and came no farther. The heat here struck his face, crawled into his nostrils and throat. For a man who had lived so long in cold, this was unbearable. He pressed his chest, breathing hard. Sweat beaded on his strong, exhausted body.

"Give him to me. The order of the realms is not to be broken."

The woman lifted a small celadon teacup from the table, steam curling soft around her face, and did not glance up. "The crossing ends where the soul chooses to root. You know this, Charon. You have ferried enough souls to know the river does not own them."

"The river carries the soul as it is."

"Every mark is testimony," Charon said. "Every choice, every wound, every burden. I deliver the soul as it is. If you strip away its weight before judgment, what am I carrying

across the river?”

“And when the weight is all that remains?” she asked. Her voice stayed calm, but her eyes did not leave his. “When a soul has mistaken its chain for its name? I do not erase the soul. I loosen what has strangled it.”

“Judgment is not yours to give.” His voice sharpened, the ancient anger of a man who has watched endless souls try to outrun their choices rising to the surface.

“Nor is despair yours to preserve.”

“You said that once before,” he said. “I delivered a blank soul to the gates and bore the blame for it.”

The woman stood, slow, and walked to the stove. She lifted the iron ladle from the pot of soup. “Then watch this one. If his soul still bears the need for judgment, I will bring him to your gates myself.”

Before Charon could answer, Lin stood. The notebook was still clutched to his chest, his knuckles white. He looked first at the old man, who had lifted his head and was staring at him with wet, wide eyes. Then at Charon, then at the woman by the stove.

His voice was steady, though confusion thickened in his chest and his hands kept shaking.

“What reckoning?” he asked. “What is it I’m supposed to answer for?”

The pavilion went quiet. The only sounds were the river outside, the crackle of the stove, the slow burn of the incense stick in the corner.

“You know what you’ve done.” Charon said.

“I didn’t run.” Lin’s voice cracked. He flipped the notebook open to the page of repeated

lines, holding it up—not to Charon, but to the old man. “I didn’t run. I just— I was scared. I was so scared she’d be angry. That I’d failed her.”

“The mortal memory will fade,” she said. “That is the nature of my brew. But the soul’s true shape, the marks of its choices, the weight of its love—these do not vanish so easily. If he still belongs to your judgment after he drinks, I will deliver him.”

Charon was silent for a long moment. His gaze moved from Lin’s tight face, to the old man beside him, to the bowl on the table, to the incense stick burning in the corner.

“One incense stick,” he said at last. His voice was low, unyielding, but without anger now. “When it burns down, the soul’s fate is sealed. If he still needs judgment, you deliver him.”

“Then his place is settled,” she said.

“The River of Forgetfulness receives every suffering soul that crosses it,” she said, light and firm, as she brushed a strand of hair back from her face, “and protects them until they return home.”

“I do not answer to your river.” Charon leaned his pole against the pavilion post, his gaze fixed on the thin incense stick burning in the corner, already counting down the moments. “I answer to the order of the realms. And to the soul’s choice. That is all.”

“The heart that longs for home will find it, no matter the river it crosses.” She tilted her chin toward him, calm and unyielding. “No one can stop that. Not even you.”

The old man was still bent over, gathering the loose pages from the floor. He gathered them with clumsy haste, fingers trembling.

One sheet remained in Lin’s own hand. In Chinese.

“The Berlin winter nights feel endless. Like my life now.

No one knows that time is the gentlest blade.

Maybe one day, I will choose to leave here myself.”

The ink had blurred. He blinked and understood: it was his own sight.

Suddenly, an old, persistent ringtone shattered everything.

Lin fumbled for his phone in panic. This scene had played out again and again in his life, endless.

But now—he looked down, and his breath stopped.

Full signal. Incoming call: Mom.

Beside him, the old man flinched violently. Shoulders hunched. Head turned away. One hand slammed over his ear, fingers pressed to his temple. Mouth clamped shut. Chest curled inward. Pain and anguish drawn across his whole body.

The phone kept ringing.

Lin’s thumb touched the answer button—

The old man lunged. The hand that had been trembling all along was suddenly steady. He snatched the phone, didn’t look at the screen, didn’t hesitate, and flung it into the river beyond the pavilion.

The phone arced through the air. The screen still glowed. “Mom” flashed once. Then it struck the water. A splash. The ringing stopped. The light on the surface wavered, sank. Ripples spread, touched the stone steps, drifted back. Soon nothing remained.

Lin stood frozen. His hand still held the shape of the phone—fingers slowly opened, then slowly clenched.

“You—”

The old man faced him, chest heaving. No malice or madness in his face. Only a terrifying, complete calm.

“Stop waiting,” the old man said. His voice was hoarse, but each word was clear.

Lin looked at him. At the lines around his eyes—the same lines that would one day be his own. At his back, bent from years of coughing. At his heavy body. At his soaked, threadbare old coat.

Suddenly he could say nothing. For one instant he wanted to collapse, to scream, to go mad—but then he felt that none of it mattered, none of it was worth it. Everything had already passed. He had known for a long time that “tomorrow is another day” was a lie. He had never believed the characters in novels.

Behind them, the bowl of soup still steamed on the table. The woman sat still. The ferryman’s rope hung from his hand, unmoving.

Beyond the pavilion, the edge of the sky began to show the first true signs of dawn. The sun pushed through a crack between grey clouds and white, spilling pink and gold across the clouds, across the river, across every one of them.

He stood there, looking at the old man. The dawn light fell on both of them, gilding the wet collar, the tired face. Lin suddenly felt that this light was not coming from the clouds. It was seeping out of his own body—or out of himself.

He took a step. No hesitation. No thought.

He tucked the notebook under his arm, then opened his arms, reaching around the old man’s cold, wet shoulders, and pulled that heavy, trembling body, with its phlegm-rasping

breath, into his embrace.

The old man went rigid. Like a stone, or a dead branch. Then, very slowly, he collapsed. His forehead came to rest on Lin's shoulder. His hands hung at his sides. He did not embrace back. He did not push away. He simply stopped holding himself up.

The old man's body was cold against his, but not entirely—deep under the wet cloth, a faint warmth still held on. Then Lin felt the heartbeat. Slow. Faint. And beating the same rhythm as his own. The weight was immense, almost too much to bear. And yet it was also light, light as a breath.

Like ice melting into warm water.

He closed his eyes.

He felt it now: the ache in his own shoulders. The dull throb in his left knee that came with every rainy day. The phlegm that never quite cleared from the back of his throat. He was feeling it all. Or feeling it again.

He remembered: this morning, pulling out white hairs one by one in front of the mirror. Tripping over a threshold, shattering a porcelain bowl, then struggling to push himself up from the floor. Last night, booking a flight back home, meaning to text his aunt. The lunch dishes still unwashed in the sink, the smell of soy sauce lingering. The computer waiting for him tonight, the old photographs of his mother and family he had meant to sort. Tomorrow he could go home, without computer. Oh, and the dishes—wash them first, or the kitchen would become a cockroach kingdom.

He opened his eyes. Let go of the notebook.

He reached into his pocket. The coin was still there. Cold, heavy, pressing into his palm.

The woman by the stove sat in the center of the pavilion, hands resting on her knees. The bowl of soup was still beside her, no longer steaming, but the ceramic was still warm—not from lamp or dawn, but from a light that came from within the bowl itself. Milky, soft, like moonlight settling on porcelain.

He walked toward her.

The woman looked up. Her face was very still.

He knelt. Not in worship—his legs had simply given out. All the strength he had stored up over the years was gone.

“Actually…” he said. His voice was hoarse, hardly his own.

He looked at the bowl. The soup was clear, translucent, like water but thicker. At the bottom lay a few leaves, a few flower petals, dark as if spring had been steeped into deep autumn.

“Actually, I should have come here long ago,” he said, barely audible. “What I couldn’t let go of was never her.”

He waited. For an answer, or permission. Nothing came. Only steam rising between them, then drifting apart.

He reached out. Both hands. Cradled the bowl. Warm.

He lifted it.

The surface trembled, showing his face. He stared at that face for a long time. Then he closed his eyes and raised the bowl to his lips.

The first sip.

No taste. Not bland—absent. Like air. Like water. Like the moment of waking from a

dream that had gone on too long—everything there, nothing to hold.

The second sip. A faint bitterness. Thin, hidden at the back of the tongue. Like a medicine taken long ago, the name forgotten, but the body still remembered.

The third sip. A touch of sweetness, and with it a wave of happiness, of fullness, flooding through him.

Then he knew nothing at all.

The ferryman was about to protest. But the old woman spoke: “His place is settled. You need not ferry him.”

He looked up at Lin. His eyes held no anger, no emotion at all—perhaps a trace of weariness, of closure.

“Ten million years,” he said, “and you are the first.”

He let go of the rope, turned, and stepped into his boat. The skiff rocked once, then slowly backed away into the mist. The sound of water—once, twice—then silence.

The world became white. Not a harsh white. Soft, overwhelming, like the light that rushed in when the curtains were drawn on a winter morning in childhood. No sound. No temperature. Only white, seeping into his bones, into the deepest, darkest corner where he had hidden himself all his life.

Lin did not know how long passed. A second. Ten years. Ten thousand years.

The white began to take shape.

First outlines. Then color—very faint. Cream walls. Grey curtains. A square window frame, the light outside soft and even, filling the whole room.

The room was small. A bed. A chair. On the nightstand, an enamel cup painted with

faded peonies. On the floor, a pair of cloth shoes, the toes worn thin, one lying on its side, the other upright. The air smelled of rice porridge—not the soup here, but a thinner kind, with the faint alkali scent and the slightly burnt grain smell from the edge of an iron pot.

He lay on the bed. He could not move.

The blanket was thin, washed white, patched with fine stitches. Someone sat beside the bed.

He turned his head toward her. The sun came from behind her, and he had to squint. Her face was soft in the light—blurred.

“Come.”

A very soft voice. A spoon was brought to his lips.

He opened his mouth. Rice water, warm, not hot, slid down his throat.

“Good child,” the woman said.

Hearing those words, something stirred inside him.

He opened his mouth to speak, but nothing came out.

The spoon came again.

He took the second sip. The rice water traveled down to his chest, to where something had been lodged—hard, jagged, a stone he could not swallow. Now the stone was shrinking and dissolving, into the rice water, into his stomach, into his blood, becoming part of his warmth.

He exhaled. Very light.

Somewhere outside, a distant sound—a market, maybe, or wind. He did not listen. He was watching her hand. The hand holding the enamel cup. Short nails. Broad knuckles. An

old scar across the base of the thumb. He stared at that scar for a long time.

He closed his eyes.

The spoon touched his lips again. He opened his mouth. The third sip.

His hand, outside the blanket, slowly relaxed.

Something slipped from his palm. Very small, very light. It fell onto the edge of the bed, bounced once, rolled across the sheet, and dropped to the floor.

It struck the cement twice, spun in a circle, and lay still.

Ting.

The light from the window moved slowly, falling on the rim of the cup, on the back of her hand, on his closed eyelids.

Her hand reached over and pulled the blanket higher, tucking it under his chin.

“Sleep,” she said.

He dreamed, it seemed, of a river very far away.

The sound of water—once, twice—then silence.

Memory, Guilt, and Return: Reflections on Writing “The Unanswered Call”

“The Unanswered Call” traces a life ensnared in the interweaving threads of forgetfulness and procrastination, portraying an individual adrift between memory and reality. The protagonist Lin Yi spent his last twenty-four years trapped by the call he missed, his mother’s final call. His life seemed never to leave that day. Time and fate wound around him like a cyclical curse. Owing to a peculiar state of being, he came after death to a borderland where Chinese and Western underworlds meet. Memory, duty, and the anxiety of existence crossed into an obscure and delicate tableau.

The original aim was to explore, through fiction, the differing conceptions of death in Chinese and Western mythologies. Yet as the writing advanced, a deeper strand surfaced, an inquiry into guilt that wears the mask of love. It examines how an individual searches for balance between what cannot be forgotten and what cannot be borne. At the same time, the figure of the unanswered call embodies a modern dread, the fear of choosing and of letting go, the condition of being forbidden total forgetting yet unable to sustain memory’s full weight. This subject touches not only private psychology. It reaches toward a perennial human seeking, an eternal love, a final reckoning, a lasting answer to the demands of existence.

The reflections that follow hover around several core concerns: how the story uses sensory detail and narrative pacing to enact the principle of “showing” rather than “telling”; how the characters undergo psychological and ethical shifts under the repeated press of time and event; how the writing process seeks a balance and a cadence between metaphor and direct statement, between syntactic rhythm and the filtering of perspective. Taken together, these reflections illuminate the ways in which “The Unanswered Call” harnesses

contemporary narrative techniques, intertwining classical and mythological lenses to excavate the perennial human dialectic of memory and oblivion.

1. Creative Aims and Core Themes

In “The Unanswered Call,” Lin Yi’s guilt and self-reproach are mistaken for love. He believed that remembering every moment of guilt was the expression of love; that never forgetting was protection of his mother. This echoic behavior and psychological state correspond to what psychoanalysis terms “repetition compulsion,” the individual’s urge to reenact painful events, as if action could dissolve an inner contradiction (Freud 13-17). In truth, his “love” had long been held hostage by deferral and avoidance, delaying the return call, delaying the visit, delaying any true communication. The bitter irony is that only after his mother’s death did this twisted “love” reach its apex. It functions as a pathological self-binding, a self-administered consolation, and a psychological pillar for the remainder of his life, absurd in its constancy. Lin Yi wished to shoulder responsibility yet could not face the full measure of the pain so that his consciousness loops through past and present, as if time were extended and folded, mirroring the dreamlike, recursive interplay of reality and fantasy found in Borges’s “The Circular Ruins” (47, 50).

In the quarrel between Charon and Meng Po, Lin Yi is forced to confront the nature of memory, accountability, and love. Charon insists that every scar must enter the final reckoning together with the soul. He refuses the erasure of memory, holding fast to the authenticity of responsibility. Meng Po, by way of the symbolic soup, intervenes not simply to make the soul forget but to loosen the chains of guilt, allowing Lin Yi’s soul to perceive

again the shape of a whole life. Their conflict discloses a core proposition: forgetting is neither pardon nor betrayal, and preserving memory does not equal bearing responsibility. Lin Yi must choose between letting go and holding on. After journeying through the underworld alongside Old Lin, his true bodily soul, he gradually grasps that genuine love is not the stubborn guarding of guilt. Love reveals itself rather in acceptance, release, and reconciliation.

In his final act, Lin Yi drinks Meng Po's soup, accepts death, yet keeps his feeling for his mother. This choice incarnates the deeper theme: memory and guilt cannot be erased, but the soul can learn to bear them and find a measure of peace. Lin Yi cannot literally return to his mother, and the unanswered call remains unanswered. The story's theme lies not only in reconciliation with the past, but in his acceptance of its impossibility—a meditation on love, memory, and the limits of return. Whether what follows is rebirth, a coma, or only a dream remains undecided. The open ending preserves the polysemy of the theme. Such an ending deepens the core inquiry into guilt and memory while sustaining a tension both ironic and philosophical. It is neither pure comedy nor pure tragedy, but an ironic meditation on love, memory, and the impossibility of return.

2. Literary Influences and Writing Practice

If the entrance to “The Unanswered Call” is a single phone call, what it truly opens is a question about whether reality itself can be trusted. Borges's “The Circular Ruins” shaped the story not through direct borrowing of plot, but through a more hidden structural temperament. At the beginning, Lin Yi dies while revising a sentence from Borges, a line

about realizing that one is also an appearance dreamed by another. It prepares the instability between dream, reality, death, and self-recognition. After Lin Yi enters the underworld, he does not simply arrive in an external realm. He seems to walk into the circular maze of his own consciousness. The unanswered call rings again and again. The phone repeatedly shows “Mom” and “No Service.” He reaches for it, fails, and reaches again, as if trapped inside different echoes of the same moment. This recalls the ending of “The Circular Ruins,” where the dreamer discovers that he too is being dreamed. Thus, cyclical time in my story is not a decorative fantasy device. It is the very form of Lin Yi’s spiritual imprisonment. Twenty-four years of life become a slow circling beneath the shadow of a single day. Borges’s influence lies in this narrative method, where the self believes itself awake, yet is judged by another layer of dream.

Then Kazuo Ishiguro’s *A Pale View of Hills* offered a different kind of guidance, one concerned with fracture, restraint, and unreliable recollection. Ishiguro’s narration often refuses to explain trauma too quickly. Instead, pain hides inside detail, smell, silence, and misplaced memory. My story attempts something similar. Rather than directly announcing Lin Yi’s suffering, it lets pain seep out through objects and sensory traces. The smell of ginger, scallion, and soy sauce reaches Lin Yi before understanding does, leading him to mistake Meng Po’s pavilion for the presence of his mother. These sensory details make memory incomplete, yet more truthful. Lin Yi does not remember his mother all at once. He is pulled back by smell, sound, and objects, little by little. The reader, like Lin Yi, must move among fragments. Old Lin’s identity, the ownership of the notebook, and Meng Po’s true intention do not come through explanation. They emerge slowly, through recognition.

The story also requires a space capable of carrying judgment and moral weight. Dante's *Inferno* enters here, chiefly through the moral architecture of the underworld. My story does not reproduce Dante's circles of Hell, yet it borrows the essential pattern of journey as judgment. Lin Yi's passage through the underworld is a forced moral movement. From the black riverbank and Charon's boat, to the red spider lilies, Meng Po's pavilion, and finally the white room, each space corresponds to another layer of his soul's distress. Charon, especially, stands close to the boundary-keeper of the Dantean tradition. He insists that the soul must carry all its marks to judgment. Memory, wounds, choices, and burdens become the testimony of the soul. This echoes the moral order of *Inferno*, where the dead are placed according to the shape of their earthly choices. Yet "The Unanswered Call" does not wholly stand on the side of judgment. Meng Po's presence opens a fissure in that moral structure. If a soul has been compressed by guilt into one single point of pain, can that still be called its true shape? Dante gives the story order, boundary, and the feeling of an end. My own alteration lies in allowing the Eastern idea of release to enter the Western structure of judgment, so that the two traditions question each other rather than replace each other (Dante, *Inf.* 3.1–9).

Yet if the underworld remained only a grand architecture of judgment, the characters would risk becoming puppets of ideas. Beckett's *Waiting for Godot* helped draw the story back toward waiting, pause, repetition, and helpless gesture. In the story, Lin Yi repeatedly takes out his phone, puts it away, and takes it out again. This small action reveals more than any confession could. He waits for signal and his mother's voice. He waits for a tomorrow that can no longer arrive. Charon's rowing sound, "plash... plash..." also works like an ancient and indifferent beat. It carries the characters forward, but offers no answer.

This rhythm gives the story a quiet absurd sorrow. A person knows the call cannot connect, yet still tries to answer. A person knows the past cannot be rewritten, yet still guards that instant with his whole life. The open ending also carries something of Beckett's suspension. Lin Yi may be reborn. He may be unconscious. He may have awakened from a dream. Or perhaps he has never truly left death. The answer is deliberately withheld. Meaning does not rest in resolution, but in the moment when waiting finally stops.

All these influences eventually return to craft. In *Writing Fiction*, Janet Burroway, Elizabeth Stuckey-French, and Ned Stuckey-French explain that fiction should not merely hand ideas to the reader. It should make ideas pass through the body, senses, and actions of the characters. Their discussion of "showing and telling" stresses that fiction must reproduce the emotional impact of experience, and that significant detail should be concrete while also carrying value and meaning (Burroway et al. 22–24). This is precisely what "The Unanswered Call" tries to practice. Lin Yi's guilt is not stated simply as "he is in pain." It appears through the repeated vibration of the phone, the cold coin pressed into his palm, the notebook falling into water, and the ink bleeding across its pages. His mother does not return through a long explanation of the past. She returns through ginger, scallion, soy sauce, and the small porcelain sound of a spoon touching a bowl. These details are the bones of feeling. Burroway and her coauthors also describe writing as "mind-farming," a process of plowing, planting, weeding, and waiting for growth that cannot be forced (Burroway et al. 15-16). This image closely resembles my own process in writing the story. The first seed was only the meeting of Chinese and Western underworlds. Through revision, deletion, patience, and

return, a deeper subject slowly grew from it. What imprisons Lin Yi is not simply his mother's death, but his long habit of mistaking guilt for love.

Literary influence, then, is not an external decoration. It works like roots beneath the soil. It moves through structure, rhythm, image, and choice, until a single unanswered call grows into a dark journey through memory, death, and the impossibility of return.

3. Genre and Literary Context

From the perspective of genre, "The Unanswered Call" cannot be neatly filed under traditional myth rewriting, nor does it belong simply to fantasy in its conventional sense. It is more accurately understood as a work of contemporary speculative fiction that brings together underworld narrative, the modern reimagining of myth, and psychological realism. On one hand it borrows the ancient figures of the ferryman, Meng Po, and the red spider lilies, supplying the story with the formal frame of a death journey. On the other, it shifts narrative centre from mythic order itself towards individual consciousness, emotional residue, and the trauma of memory. In this way, the underworld transformed into an outward projection of the protagonist's inward life.

Within this generic framework, traditional underworld figures are re-situated in a modern context. The Ferryman and Meng Po are endowed with more complex narrative duties. Meng Po, in particular, is not simply the keeper of forgetting but more like a witness suspended between judgment and compassion, guiding Lin Yi through the shards of memory and turning the whole underworld passage into something closer to an act of self-recognition than a straightforward soul trial. The space of death and the space of the psyche overlap.

Supernatural scenes and ordinary details interpenetrate. The story's true forward movement depends less on event than on the gradual emergence of consciousness, layer by layer.

Finally, the work both observes certain conventions of the underworld journey narrative and deliberately departs from them. Traditionally, this motif in this kind of work tends to emphasize descent, trial, revelation, and return; the traveler undergoes some moral or spiritual transformation through passage into another realm. "The Unanswered Call," however, turns away from the outward spectacle of ordeal and returns insistently to hesitation, recollection, misrecognition, and the inability to let go. The fantastic elements also serve to illuminate the inward condition of the protagonist. The form of the mythic descent remains, but its heroic pattern is redirected inward, toward grief, guilt, and the delayed labor of self-understanding.

4. Character Transformation

Lin Yi's transformation runs through the entire story. He begins as a middle-aged man frozen by an unanswered call, trapped inside a loop of memory, and is gradually compelled to grasp the finality of a life and the irrecoverable nature of the past. His change is not merely physical. It is rooted just as deeply in the mind and in feeling. The doubled presence of Young Lin and Old Lin is not simply a contrast between age, or between reality and hallucination. It also signifies a split between body and psyche, memory and consciousness. Young Lin embodies action, fantasy, and unresolved guilt. Old Lin, by contrast, represents fate, recognition, and emotional maturity. Their interweaving makes Lin's inner conflict visible and brings out the dense entanglement of guilt, love, and memory.

On the physical level, Lin first refuses to accept his fifty-six-year-old body. His movements are heavy, his joints ache, and the black shale seems to press him down. As the story advances, the borders of his body and the physical world begin to blur. He passes through sensations of lightness and burning heat, until death itself arrives. His body dissolves, his biological timeline is forcibly closed. This alteration marks a fate reshaped by the logic of the underworld rather than by any act of personal will. Gustav Freytag's structural model makes itself felt here. The exposition finds Lin in a state of stasis, trapped by the missed call. The rising action carries him through repeated returns to memory and underworld encounters. The climax is his full recognition of his own self-deception, his psychological burden, and his guilt. The falling action and resolution manifest as a slow psychic yielding (Freytag 137-40).

Psychologically, Lin clings to the belief that language, communication, and confirmation can repair what was left undone in life. He treats "Mom" as a presence that can still be properly reached, called back, or verified through a stable signal. Though his body is fifty-six, his inner clock has stopped at thirty-two, the day his mother died, the day the unanswered call became the axis of his identity. The underworld forces him to understand that guilt cannot be resolved by language or by action. He must confront what lies beyond articulation, scent, heat, the pressure of habit, the raw fact of touch.

The ending of "The Unanswered Call" is therefore neither pure tragedy nor unclouded comic restoration. Northrop Frye distinguishes tragedy and comedy as two fundamental movements. Tragedy isolates the protagonist from his world. Comedy typically reintegrates the figure into a community (Frye 36-37, 163-64). Lin Yi drinks Meng Po's soup and he seems to accept death. Yet the white room, with its hospital-like stillness, grants no

genuine return. It may be a near-death awakening. It may be an infant's rebirth. It may be the residual murmur of a vegetative consciousness. It may be only the last ripple of an underworld dream. The small metal object that falls, half evidence, half hallucination, keeps the ending from resolving into a settled answer. The story stands closer to what Frye terms the ironic mode. Irony "says less," leaving meaning suspended, inviting the reader to feel the cold weight of its implications for themselves. At the same time, irony frequently circles back from realism toward myth, so that the ancient patterns of death, sacrifice, and return glimmer faintly through the modern scene (Frye 47, 51). Lin Yi is neither fully saved nor entirely destroyed. The peace he gains is ambiguous and fragile. The call was never answered. The mother cannot return. What is called waking, rebirth, or survival may be no more than a thin cloth of near-hope draped over the hard fact of no return.

On the emotional level, Lin moves from anxiety and bargaining toward understanding and submission. He once tries to earn forgiveness by "answering the call." But when he confronts the order of the underworld and the presence of Old Lin, he realizes that every effort is futile. Young Lin lives within the fantasy that the past might somehow be redone. Old Lin forces him to see that no action can reset what has already happened. Their encounters reveal a misalignment between body and psyche, between time and memory. Lin chooses, at last, to accept the unalterable.

On the symbolic level, the Rivers, the notebook, and the red spider lily externalize Lin's inner transformation. The river signifies time's irreversible flow. The notebook signifies the desire to fix memory in words. The flower suggests the passing and transmutation of feeling. These symbols work together with psychological narration to make

Lin's transformation both concrete and philosophical.

What "The Unanswered Call" inscribes, in the final reckoning, is not solely the private bereavement and fixation of one Lin Yi. It is the shared spiritual predicament of the modern soul. We defer. We grow anxious. We postpone love to some next time, as though the missed call need only ring once more for everything to be repaired. Yet what the story truly wishes to say is perhaps not that we should wait for the phone to ring again, not that we should cling to a belated reply. It is that we might, before everything is lost, dial the call ourselves. Speak the love ourselves. Walk toward the other ourselves. In some sense, each of us is Lin Yi. Each of us has been caught inside words never spoken, affections never given form, regrets never laid to rest. The ending of the story may be unalterable. But the one who reads it may still draw from it a gentle instruction: in a life that is finite and irreversible, do not leave love for later. Do not stake meaning on an imaginary second chance. In this moment, now, go out to love, to understand, to arrive. So the unanswered call ceases to be an emblem of regret. It becomes a quiet and lucid reminder, tender in its warning.

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